

**of Bangalore techies
surveyed are probable
psychiatric cases**

One among

**employees regularly
considers suicide**

**were constantly
under strain**

**of 900 men and
women faced
infertility problems**

Source: NIMHANS survey, December 2007

cent are unable to enjoy daily activities and a fifth that admit to being edgy and bad-tempered all the time. It is a life that comes at a price, where one among 20 employees is considering the idea of suicide. For a section of the country's population that has to adjust its schedules according to the work timings of the Occident, it comes as little surprise. For Arnab Bagechi, a BPO worker in Hyderabad, a 2 p.m. to 10 p.m. timing is very natural. "Of course, I lose out on the evenings, but I was always a late riser," he says. Others are not that forgiving. Maitreyee Chaliha,

an IT employee, says her husband's mid-night conference calls really bother her. Then there's Sudha Sharma who can't remember the last time she watched a leisurely three-hour movie. Life, for her, is on permanent hold, including the children she desperately wants.

Living life in a different time zone is not exactly the ideal working model but that is exactly where most IT careers start, as new entrants are sucked into a whole new lifestyle right after college with a white-collar dream that promises one thing and delivers another. At 25-28, they are living their dreams of owning fancy cars and plush apartments, but for a hefty price.

For singles, it becomes increasingly difficult to socialise. Debajan Ghosh, 29, has been shuttling among three continents for the last five years. He is currently in the US and is due to move to India in a fortnight. "I don't know yet which city I'm supposed to move to," he says. It could be Bangalore, Pune, Mumbai or Hyderabad, where his parents are based, but he will only get to know a couple of days before leaving his current workstation. "How do I marry with so much uncertainty in my life?" he says. Ghosh has finally decided to go for an arranged marriage, after his parents fixed him up with a girl who is also in the IT sector.

Nandini Chakraborty, who runs a new-age matrimonial agency in Bangalore called Marrygold, says 50 per cent of her agency's clients belong to the IT sector. Her agency does not match people on the basis of caste, creed or religion. It services people who either don't have the time or the energy to socialise, or are unable to find like-minded persons. "We try to bring together people who have similar profiles, and it's not just for marriage," says Chakraborty. Most of her clients are well-settled and educated. And IT makes up a huge chunk of it.

It is when an IT employee gets married that the real problem begins—due to conflicting schedules, ego-tussles and demands. "Couples are so busy pursuing their careers these days that they don't realise their biological clock is ticking," says Kamini Rao, infertility expert and director of the Bangalore Assisted Conception Centre. She says one out of three couples who come to her centre for advice are from the IT sector and

most are in the 25-35 age group.

A couple of years ago, a Bangalore-based institute conducted a study to identify the incidence and types of reproductive problems IT couples face. It found that out of the 900 patients examined in a year, 180 had not consummated their marriage, 300, both men and women, had infertility problems, 200 suffered from penile dysfunction, and 99 had what is known as sexual anorexia or a decreased libido. Experts reckon stress may be the culprit in a lot of cases. Sexual dysfunction apart, it is the unwillingness to compromise on their lifestyles by having a child that gives rise to another set of problems.

For Amitabh and Debrupa Gupta, Bangalore-based IT professionals who are in the process of migrating to Australia, a child is a no-no at least for the next three years. While their new jobs may offer better pay packets, settling in a new country and tying all loose ends pulls back this couple's family plans. "We need to at least see whether the new country will be a good place to settle," says Debrupa.

Most IT companies are waking up to the health risks of their employees. While Oracle has pranik healing workshops to combat stress, there are helplines and resident psychiatrists in most companies to assure their workers' mental health. Work-from-home options, regular social events and reduced workdays are some of the perks being increasingly offered. But there are two areas the helplines can't look into. One, they do not assess an employee's mental resilience before recruitment, and two, they offer sustained professional counselling. NIMHANS survey quotes WHO estimates which say that despite all the initiatives taken by companies, only five to 10 per cent of the workers in developing countries have access to occupational health services. The survey says, "In developing countries, people are not aware of the importance of dealing with work-related stress. This will have future negative consequences for the health, safety and well-being of workers."

NIMHANS is considering a speciality clinic for IT employees and their specific ailments. But with a workforce that is daily growing in alarming proportions, it may be too little too late. ■